

EDITORIAL · WHAT COUNTS IN THE AGE OF AI?

What Counts as Learning in the Age of AI?

Why higher education must rethink evidence, authorship, and assessment.

By Dr Jabreel Asghar · 21 July 2026

The other day, I proudly showed my 12-year-old daughter a website I had designed with the help of an AI coding assistant. She adamantly rejected it as my work. Her academic training has taught her that working with AI tools is discouraged, even though she has been using AI effectively to understand complex concepts across the curriculum. At work, I have frequently heard people refer to AI use as if it were something to be concealed rather than acknowledged. Public debates also often frame AI as a competitor to human intelligence rather than as a catalyst for reconsidering how intelligence is demonstrated and assessed.

Every major educational technology has been greeted with predictions of decline. Plato worried that writing itself would weaken memory. The printing press was initially accused of encouraging superficial knowledge and weakening memory and oral scholarship. Calculators were going to destroy arithmetic skills. The rise of internet search prompted concerns about superficial learning, declining memory, and plagiarism. Most recently, the use of AI has raised questions about the authorship, assessment, and legitimacy of work.

However, concerns about innovation have not always been unfounded. Television has contributed to sedentary lifestyles. Social media has also brought well-documented social costs. History shows that every technology creates both gains and losses. The question is how institutions adapt.

We have previously faced similar transitional phases in education. Corpus linguistics and digital databases changed how linguistic research is conducted. Likewise, grammar and language-editing software altered academic writing workflows. Each technology automated something previously considered an essential human skill, yet education did not disappear. Instead, it redefined which skills mattered.

For generations, students and scholars have used tools to handle drudgery. In language, we have moved from dictionaries to spell-checkers and then autocorrect. No serious educator today believes that students must manually memorise every spelling rule to demonstrate mastery of a subject. In mathematics and statistics, we teach students when and why to run a t-test or regression, not how to perform all the arithmetic by hand. EndNote, Zotero, and Mendeley handle much of the mechanical work of formatting bibliographies. The intellectual task is understanding why citation matters, not memorising obscure punctuation rules.

Yet these tools did not eliminate the need for human judgement. They changed where judgement was required. Large language models and generative AI push that boundary further.

We need to distinguish between outsourcing effort and outsourcing judgement. By outsourcing effort, I mean the scaffolding activities that support the real intellectual work but can be offloaded without destroying understanding. Outsourcing judgement, by contrast, involves delegating higher-order processes: evaluation, synthesis, originality, ethical reasoning, taste, and final decision-making. This is where the learner's voice, critical judgement, and accountability reside. Education has comfortably accepted the outsourcing of effort for decades—often centuries—while fiercely guarding judgement.

Previous educational technologies primarily automated procedures or information retrieval. Generative AI automates the production of linguistically coherent reasoning and argumentation. Unlike calculators, word processors, and Google Search, which outsourced execution or retrieval, AI outsources aspects of reasoning expressed through language. Large language models produce explanations, arguments, interpretations, and critiques. This is a qualitative shift, and it helps explain why assessment is under growing pressure to change.

The challenge is therefore not deciding whether outsourcing is acceptable—it already is. The real question is which forms of judgement should remain demonstrably human. Although AI can automate aspects of reasoning and pattern generation, accountability, contextual judgement, and responsibility cannot be delegated.

This means that adaptation must go beyond tool adoption. Teaching and assessment must be redesigned around the kinds of thinking that remain educationally and socially valuable. Traditionally, assessment has often inferred learning from the quality of the finished artefact. Generative AI has weakened the assumption that a polished written product is reliable evidence of individual learning. An AI-generated artefact may resemble expert reasoning, but it is no longer sufficient evidence that learning has taken place.

The mistake is not using AI. The mistake is assuming that assessment designed for a pre-AI world can still measure learning in the same way. Universities have spent the past several years asking whether students should use AI. History suggests a different question: which aspects of intellectual work can responsibly be delegated, and which must remain demonstrably human?

The future of assessment depends not on prohibiting assistance, but on defining the boundary between assistance and judgement.

Returning to my daughter's reaction to the AI-assisted website I built, we can see how education's ambivalent relationship with AI shapes students' understanding of authorship. My daughter readily uses AI to learn, yet instinctively believes that AI-assisted work is less authentically authored. That paradox captures today's educational culture. Every transformative educational technology changes not only how people learn, but also what institutions must accept as credible evidence of learning.

About this editorial

This editorial is the first in the ten-part series What Counts in the Age of AI?, which examines how generative AI is reshaping learning, institutional response, authorship, teaching, expertise, assessment, critical thinking, creativity, trust, and what remains distinctively human in higher education.

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Part 1 of 10 in the series What Counts in the Age of AI?

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